

# Fruit Trees for Colorado Springs

A working reference for residents, Forestry, and partner nonprofits considering fruit trees as part of the Colorado Springs urban canopy.

## What this place is, climatically

| Factor                       | Colorado Springs                                                            |
|------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Elevation                    | 6,000–7,500 ft (city center ~6,035 ft)                                      |
| USDA hardiness zone          | 5b in most of the city; 4 in the western foothills and toward Monument Hill |
| Frost-free season            | ~150 days, mid-May through early October                                    |
| Annual precipitation         | ~16 inches, semi-arid                                                       |
| Largest single risk to fruit | Late spring frosts that kill blossoms before fruit sets                     |

The practical implication: trees that bloom *late* and tolerate a sudden frost are reliable here. Trees that bloom early (apricots, most peaches) are gamblers — beautiful, sometimes wonderful, but they'll lose a crop in maybe one year out of three.

## The reliability tiers

**Tier 1 — Reliable.** Apples, sour cherries, plums (especially American hybrids), and pears. These set fruit in most years with reasonable care.

**Tier 2 — Workable with the right variety.** Sweet cherries (cold-hardy varieties only), peaches (only the hardiest cultivars), and serviceberries.

**Tier 3 — Gamblers.** Apricots, nectarines, figs. Possible at lower elevations in protected microclimates; not for a public-program default list.

## Apples (Tier 1 — the foundation)

The workhorse. Hardy, productive, multiple uses (fresh, cider, sauce, baking, drying), excellent for wildlife when fruit drops, and the broadest variety selection at any local nursery. Most apples need a second variety nearby for cross-pollination, which is a *feature* for community plantings — pairs of trees per site.

| Variety            | Mature size          | Notes for our climate                                   |
|--------------------|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| Honeycrisp         | Semi-dwarf 12-16 ft  | Crisp, sweet, very popular. Reliable producer.          |
| Haralson           | Semi-dwarf 12-16 ft  | University of Minnesota; built for cold. Tart-sweet.    |
| Sweet Sixteen      | Semi-dwarf 12-16 ft  | Aromatic. Stores into December.                         |
| Wealthy            | Semi-dwarf 12-16 ft  | Old-time variety, very hardy, early bearing.            |
| Liberty            | Semi-dwarf 12-16 ft  | Disease resistant — good for low-spray programs.        |
| Prairie Spy        | Semi-dwarf 12-16 ft  | Late ripening, excellent keeper.                        |
| Yellow Transparent | Semi-dwarf 12-16 ft  | Early summer apple, soft, great for sauce.              |
| Apple Babe         | Genetic dwarf 6-8 ft | True dwarf. Excellent for tight spaces and kids' reach. |

## Sour / Pie Cherries (Tier 1 — the hidden gem)

These are perhaps the easiest fruit trees in Colorado: hardy, naturally disease- and insect-resistant, beautiful bark, and self-pollinating (one tree is enough). Less famous than sweet cherries because they're tart raw — but the flavor for pie, jam, juice, and dried cherries is unmatched.

| Variety              | Mature size | Notes                                                          |
|----------------------|-------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Montmorency          | 12-16 ft    | The classic. Most reliable in our area. Self-fertile.          |
| North Star           | 6-8 ft      | Genetic dwarf — kid-height. Productive. Self-fertile.          |
| Meteor               | 10-14 ft    | Genetic dwarf, U. of Minnesota. Self-fertile.                  |
| Bali (Evan's Cherry) | 12-14 ft    | Reportedly hardy to 9,000 ft on the Front Range. Self-fertile. |
| Mesabi               | 10-12 ft    | Cross of sweet × sour; sweeter than Montmorency.               |

## Sweet Cherries (Tier 2 — pick carefully)

Sweet cherries struggle in our cold spring snaps. They're better on the Western Slope (Palisade) than the Front Range. The exception is Bali, listed above as a sour cherry but technically a hardy sweet-tart hybrid. If sweet cherries are wanted, plant at lower elevation, in protected sites, and pair with a pollinator.

| Variety         | Notes                                                       |
|-----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| Stella          | Self-fertile sweet cherry, more reliable than Bing here.    |
| Lapins          | Self-fertile, large dark red fruit.                         |
| Black Tartarian | Needs a pollinator. Reasonably cold-hardy.                  |
| Rainier         | Yellow-blush sweet cherry. Needs pollinator. Less reliable. |

## Plums (Tier 1 — the workhorse for low-maintenance)

Plums shrug off most insects and diseases that bother apples. They stay smaller than apples or cherries, fit in tight spaces, and the American/Japanese hybrids are bred for cold climates. Many varieties want a pollinator (plant pairs).

| Variety     | Mature size | Notes                                                          |
|-------------|-------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Mount Royal | 12–15 ft    | Canadian. European-type plum, very cold-hardy, self-fertile.   |
| Pipestone   | 12–15 ft    | American–Japanese hybrid. Sweet yellow flesh. Very hardy.      |
| Toka        | 12–15 ft    | Hardy, fragrant flowers. Excellent pollinator for other plums. |
| Stanley     | 12–15 ft    | European prune-plum, self-fertile, dries well.                 |
| Superior    | 12–15 ft    | American–Japanese hybrid. Large red fruit.                     |

## Pears (Tier 1, slow start)

Pears are cold-hardy and drought-tolerant once established, but they're slow to bear (5–7 years). All require a second pear variety nearby for pollination — bees do most of the work, so think pollinator habitat too.

| Variety     | Mature size | Notes                                       |
|-------------|-------------|---------------------------------------------|
| Patten      | 15–20 ft    | One of the hardiest. Reliable producer.     |
| Ure         | 12–15 ft    | Bred for the Canadian prairies. Very hardy. |
| Early Gold  | 15 ft       | Early August harvest, golden fruit.         |
| Bartlett    | 15–20 ft    | Classic. Workable here at lower elevations. |
| Summercrisp | 15 ft       | U. of Minnesota; very cold hardy.           |

### Peaches (Tier 2 — only the hardiest cultivars)

Most peach varieties die back or fail to set fruit here. A short list of cold-tolerant cultivars is genuinely workable in protected sites, but expect to lose a crop in late-frost years.

| Variety   | Mature size         | Notes                                                             |
|-----------|---------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Reliance  | ~15 ft              | The hardiest. Reportedly bears after –20°F winters. Self-fertile. |
| Contender | ~15 ft              | Matches Reliance for cold-hardiness, late-blooming.               |
| Redhaven  | ~15 ft              | Disease resistant; the standard for upper-elevation orchards.     |
| Bonfire   | Genetic dwarf, 6 ft | Ornamental burgundy foliage + edible. Fits anywhere.              |

### Apricots (Tier 3 — optional)

Beautiful trees, but they bloom in late March or early April when frosts are still very common here. Even the late-blooming varieties (Moorpark, Goldcot) lose blossoms most years. Acceptable as ornamentals; don't promise a fruit harvest.

### Native and naturalized fruit-bearers (the underrated tier)

These are often the *best* options for community plantings, parks, trail corridors, and wildlife-focused sites: they're built for this climate, need almost no care once established, and feed pollinators and wildlife as their primary job — with edible-for-people fruit as a bonus.

| Plant                                                        | Form                                    | Edible to                          | Notes                                                                         |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Serviceberry / Saskatoon<br>( <i>Amelanchier alnifolia</i> ) | Large shrub /<br>small tree, 8–20<br>ft | People, birds,<br>bears            | Sweet blueberry-like fruit in June.<br>Spectacular fall color.                |
| Western chokecherry<br>( <i>Prunus virginiana</i> )          | Small tree, 15–25<br>ft                 | Birds, bears,<br>people (cooked)   | Native. Already used in CSU<br>plantings. Astringent raw,<br>excellent jelly. |
| Wild plum ( <i>Prunus<br/>americana</i> )                    | Small tree /<br>thicket, 10–20 ft       | People, birds,<br>foxes            | Native. Tart-sweet red fruit. Forms<br>thickets — wildlife corridor value.    |
| Hawthorn ( <i>Crataegus</i> ,<br>several spp.)               | Small tree, 15–25<br>ft                 | Songbirds, deer,<br>people (jelly) | Multiple species native. Some<br>thornless cultivars exist.                   |
| Buffaloberry ( <i>Shepherdia<br/>argentea</i> )              | Shrub, 6–18 ft                          | Birds, people                      | Native, drought-hardy, silver<br>foliage.                                     |
| Golden currant ( <i>Ribes<br/>aureum</i> )                   | Shrub, 3–6 ft                           | People, birds,<br>pollinators      | Native. Fragrant yellow flowers.<br>Tart juicy berries.                       |
| Mountain crabapple /<br>native crabapples                    | Small tree, 15–25<br>ft                 | Birds (heavy),<br>people (jelly)   | Top-tier wildlife food. Pollinator<br>magnet in spring.                       |
| Pin cherry ( <i>Prunus<br/>pensylvanica</i> )                | Small tree, 15–30<br>ft                 | Birds, bears                       | Native. Bright-red small cherries.<br>Fast-growing.                           |

## Cost ranges (2026 dollars)

| Tree size / format                         | Typical retail<br>price | Notes                                                      |
|--------------------------------------------|-------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| Bare-root, 1-yr ¾" caliper                 | \$30 – \$50             | Best value. Plant in early spring before leaf-out.         |
| Bare-root, larger                          | \$40 – \$70             | More established root system.                              |
| 5-gallon container, semi-dwarf             | \$50 – \$90             | The most common size at local nurseries.                   |
| 7–15 gallon container                      | \$90 – \$200            | Larger, faster shade/fruit.                                |
| Balled-and-burlapped (B&B), 1.5–2" caliper | \$200 – \$350           | Specimen size. What City Forestry typically plants in ROW. |

| Tree size / format                                      | Typical retail price | Notes                                                       |
|---------------------------------------------------------|----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| Genetic dwarf (Bonfire peach, Apple Babe)               | \$50 – \$80          | Compact, child-friendly, container-suitable.                |
| Multi-graft / espaliered (4-in-1 apple, fruit cocktail) | \$100 – \$250        | Multiple varieties on one tree. Pollination self-contained. |
| Native shrub (serviceberry, currant), 1–3 gal           | \$20 – \$45          | Excellent value for community plantings.                    |

For context: the City's own published estimate for the full first-five-years cost of one tree (purchase + planting + establishment care) is approximately \$1,000 per tree across all species. Fruit trees fall toward the lower end of that range for purchase, but require a bit more ongoing care than shade trees.

## Food value at a glance

### For people

| Use case                         | Best choices                                      |
|----------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| Fresh eating, year-round storage | Honeycrisp, Sweet Sixteen, Prairie Spy apples     |
| Pies, jams, preserves            | Montmorency cherry, Mount Royal plum, chokecherry |
| Cider                            | Liberty, Wealthy, multi-variety apples            |
| Drying                           | Stanley plum (a "prune plum"), apples             |
| Quick crops for kids             | Pipestone plum, North Star cherry, serviceberry   |
| Specialty / preserve-only        | Western chokecherry, golden currant, hawthorn     |

### For children (low height, sweet, easy picking)

The best children's fruit-tree plantings are knee-to-shoulder height when the kid is the harvester. That points to: **North Star sour cherry (6–8 ft)**, **Bonfire dwarf peach (6 ft)**, **Apple Babe genetic dwarf apple (6–8 ft)**, **serviceberry (shrub form, fruits at 4–6 ft)**, and **Pipestone plum** (small tree, sweet, drops to ground when ripe). Avoid hawthorns (thorns) and high-up apples for sites where kids will be picking.

A practical safety note: any fruit tree near a sidewalk or path will drop fruit, which becomes a slip hazard when it ferments. Site fruit-droppers away from walkways or expect to schedule clean-up.

## For wildlife

The single highest wildlife-value plantings are *not* the cultivated fruits — they're the natives. By order of wildlife value:

1. **Crabapples (native and ornamental)** — top food source for cedar waxwings, robins, finches, and grosbeaks. Pollinator magnet in spring. Already widely planted in Colorado Springs; expanding the native and small-fruited cultivars amplifies the existing benefit.
2. **Serviceberry** — songbirds, bears, foxes, small mammals all use the fruit. Pollinators heavy in spring.
3. **Western chokecherry** — bears, birds, foxes, coyotes; one of the highest-density wildlife foods in the Front Range.
4. **Pin cherry** — bird-heavy use, especially during migration.
5. **Hawthorn** — winter food for songbirds (fruit persists into snow); deer browse.
6. **Wild plum** — pollinators in spring, fruit eaten by birds, foxes, raccoons.
7. **Mulberry** (where it survives) — bird magnet but messy; often considered weedy.
8. **Cultivated apples and cherries** — significant when fruit is left unharvested or drops; deer, bears, foxes, raccoons, and birds will all use them.

A reasonable rule: cultivated fruit trees feed people primarily and wildlife as a bonus; native fruit-bearers feed wildlife primarily and people as a bonus. A program that mixes both gets the best of both.

## Practical considerations for a public-program list

A few things worth flagging if Forestry is thinking about expanding the fruit menu:

**Pollination requires pairs.** Most apples, pears, sweet cherries, and many plums need a second variety of the same fruit nearby (within ~100 ft). Self-fertile varieties (Stella, Mount Royal, Reliance, Stanley) are easier for single-tree sites; pairs are easier when planting whole streets or parks.

**Rootstock matters more than variety.** A "Honeycrisp" on a dwarfing rootstock and a "Honeycrisp" on a standard rootstock are nearly different trees in mature size, water needs, and time-to-fruit. EMLA-7 (semi-dwarf) is the sweet spot for most yards. Specifying rootstock on the approved list, not just variety, gives applicants a clearer picture.

**Deer protection is essential the first 2–3 years.** Young thin trunks need fencing or trunk wrap; otherwise deer rub kills the tree in one autumn. This is a per-tree cost (\$15–40) that Forestry's

existing tree-care materials may already cover.

**Pruning is annual.** Fruit trees need yearly winter pruning to stay productive and structurally sound. This is the largest difference between fruit trees and shade trees in long-term maintenance burden — and the strongest argument for a nonprofit-tending partnership.

**Fruit drop = liability + cleanup.** Sidewalk-adjacent fruit trees produce slip hazards and pest pressure (yellowjackets on fallen fruit). Sites should be set back from walkways or tied to a harvest/cleanup commitment.

**Disease pressure is lower here than in wetter climates.** Fire blight is the main worry for apples and pears; choosing resistant cultivars (Liberty, Honeycrisp for apples; Summercrisp for pears) substantially reduces the spray burden.

### A starter recommendation

If Forestry wanted a defensible, expandable fruit-tree menu to add to the Grow Shade Together private-property list, this set covers the bases without overcommitting to gamblers:

- **2 apples:** Honeycrisp + Liberty (cross-pollinate; one disease-resistant)
- **1 sour cherry:** Montmorency (self-fertile, reliable)
- **1 dwarf cherry:** North Star (kid-height, self-fertile)
- **2 plums:** Mount Royal + Toka (paired pollinators; one self-fertile)
- **1 pear:** Patten (very hardy)
- **1 hardy peach:** Reliance (acknowledged as a gamble but the hardiest)
- **3 native fruit-bearers:** Serviceberry + Western chokecherry + native crabapple

Eleven items. Covers fresh eating, preserves, wildlife, pollinators, kid-height options, and self-fertile single-tree sites. Could anchor a partnership conversation with the Colorado Tree Coalition, Pikes Peak Urban Gardens, and CSU Extension.

---

*Sources: Heidrich's Colorado Tree Farm Nursery fruit guide; Phelan Gardens fruit tree list (Colorado Springs); Rick's Garden Center bare-root fruit catalog (Colorado Springs); Bath Garden Center Front Range fruit guide (Fort Collins); CSU Extension Fact Sheet 7.423 (Trees and Shrubs for Mountain Areas); Colorado Springs City Forestry Grow Shade Together program materials.*